GLASSHOUSE

TEMPLE RUN

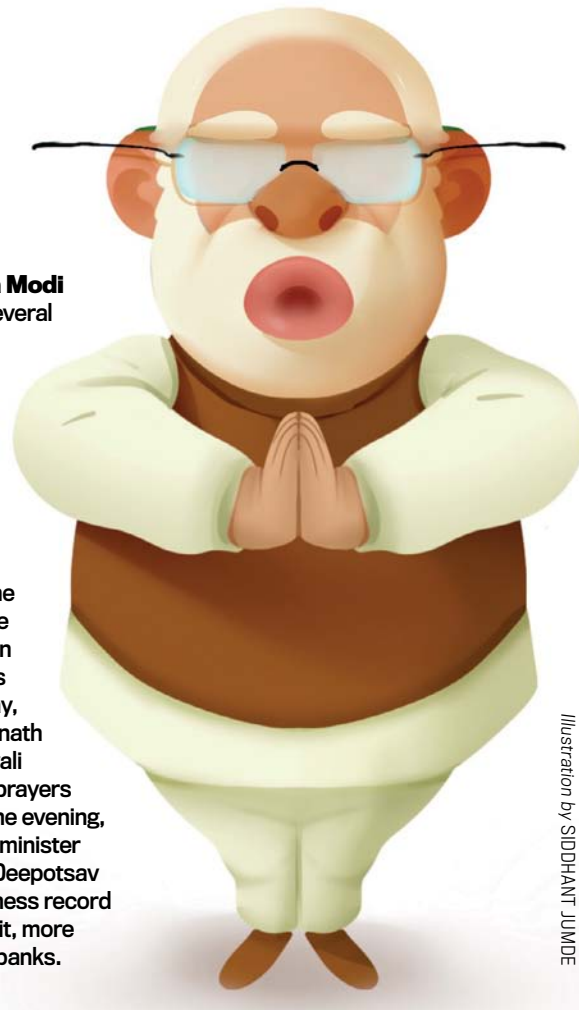


Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

Prime Minister **Narendra Modi** has been busy visiting several iconic temples in the country. Between September 30 and October 9, he visited three temples in home state Gujarat, where election is due. On October 12, the PM inaugurated Phase I of the Rs 850 crore Mahakaleshwar Temple corridor development project in Ujjain. A week later, he laid the foundation stone for the development of the Shri Krishan Rukshamani Mandir in Gujarat's Madhavpur village. The next day, he was at the Kedarnath-Badrinath shrines in Uttarakhand. On Diwali eve, October 23, Modi offered prayers to Ramlalla in Ayodhya and in the evening, along with Uttar Pradesh chief minister Yogi Adityanath, launched the Deepotsav celebrations, which set a Guinness record for maximum number of *diya*s lit, more than 1.5 million, on the Saryu's banks.

TO PRAY OR TO POACH?



BANDEEP SINGH

Political circles were abuzz when Assam chief minister and BJP leader **Himanta Biswa Sarma** recently went temple-hopping in Rajasthan, where the Congress power struggle between CM Ashok Gehlot and challenger Sachin Pilot remains unresolved. Besides visiting the Shree Salasar Balaji Temple and Khatu Shyam Mandir, Sarma also paid obeisance to Governor Kalraj Mishra and Speaker C.P. Joshi. Though dubbed courtesy visits, Sarma's reputation for political manoeuvring—witnessed in the Shiv Sena split in Maharashtra and Congress defections in Goa—is making everyone nervous.

Healthy Advice

On October 21, while speaking at a health department function, Bihar chief minister **Nitish Kumar** stopped midway when he caught an officer yawning, opening his mouth, not his ears. "This is a health department function. You must feel well," the CM said, asking the officer to at least heed the people, if not the chief minister.



ANI



Racing Ahead

As Hyderabad prepares to host the Formula E grand prix on Feb. 11 next year, **K.T. Rama Rao**, Telangana's municipal administration and urban development minister, is striving to showcase the state capital's growth as a global city. The precincts of Hussainsagar, in the heart of the city and also the race venue, are being given a facelift. This includes a martyrs' memorial for those who died fighting for separate statehood and the swank state secretariat complex, which will also be ready by then. Ruling Telangana Rashtra Samithi, too, should get a boost ahead of the 2023 polls.



MAKEOVER AND MAKING UP

Though the Uttar Pradesh government counts bulldozer action and mafia encounters among its achievements, the actions have showed the state police force, particularly on social media, in poor light. To counter the impression, the khaki force is planning a makeover, which includes a media outreach. All district police officials have been asked to be polite with the media. UP acting DGP **D.S. Chauhan** recently hosted a get-together for journalists on Diwali, held after many years, where other top cops were present. A fresh start?

Kaushik Deka with Amarnath K. Menon, Amitabh Srivastava and Prashant Srivastava